

Chapter 9

Universities, Sustainable Development and the ‘Knowledge Turn’ in Global Governance – Causes, Mechanisms and Risks



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9.1 Introduction

Since the late 1990s, the notion of the ‘global knowledge economy’ has seen wide proliferation among media, policymakers, international organizations and those actors where knowledge has traditionally been produced – universities and research institutes (Frank & Meyer, 2007, 2020). Research and innovation systems, with the modern ‘super research university’ at their core, are considered crucial in equipping economies for the twenty-first century (Baker, 2015).

I argue that the strong premium on the economic benefits of the scientific expansion in these accounts obscures other transformations at the level of universities worldwide. This chapter holds that, in the recent period, universities have entered the global governance landscape by strategically positioning themselves as global knowledge actors. This new role contrasts with an older idea of the university as a socially-buffered national entity of public administration serving a small cohort of the population, particularly in Europe (Ramirez, 2002). By contrast, this new type of university transforms itself into an organizational *actor* which is increasingly autonomous, goal-oriented, accountable and socially-embedded (Bromley & Meyer, 2015; Krücken & Meier, 2006).

While these traits apply to organizations across (public and private) sectors, universities represent a special form of organizational actorhood. One of their primary mission has always been and increasingly consists of acting on behalf of *others*. University agency is often directed to other actors which cannot act for themselves (e.g. the disadvantaged) or non-actor entities (e.g. the environment) as well as key

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principles of modernity (e.g. progress and justice) (Meyer & Jepperson, 2000; Meyer, 2019; Zapp, 2020a).

Imbued with the mission of ‘otherhood’ and supported by a growing reliance on evidence as a new basis of policymaking, it seems that universities are embedding themselves with ease into the complex web of global governance actors. Equipped with universalistic and applicable knowledge and undergoing profound internationalization in structure, staff, students and knowledge, academic expertise meets growing demand across policy areas, notably sustainable development.

Universities have discovered their new role as knowledge providers for global problems partly to live up to the noble goals of this century-old institution but also, more pragmatically, to fill drained funding lines. Policymakers and funding agencies now require research with ‘societal impact’ and media (e.g. Times Higher Education) have begun to assess universities not only by their excellence but also in terms of their contribution to solve urgent social problems (Watermeyer, 2019).

This chapter reviews the causes for such a change in the role of the university in the twenty-first century and maps out a number of mechanisms that illustrate the new role of universities. The current UN Sustainable Development Agenda can be considered a catalyst of universities’ commitment to global governance and will serve as an example. In this context, I highlight four phenomena. First, universities increasingly align their research to the demands of the global governance agenda, namely the SDGs. Such alignment not only concerns substance, i.e. research objects but also research collaboration, which now often includes key actors in global governance, i.e. international intergovernmental (IGOs) and non-governmental organizations (INGOs). Here, university knowledge slowly penetrates governance in contemporary world society.

Second, higher education institutions also transform their teaching reflecting their mission to train a new generation of experts to deal with problems on a global scale. Universities directly contribute to global governance by professionalizing globalization. They train students in international law, business, and economics, but also in global health and climate change management. As transmitters of a genuinely post-national epistemology, they socialize entire cohorts in a new global frame ready to enter increasingly borderless labor markets.

Third, universities undergo profound internal change. Long only discussed in the for-profit sector, (corporate) social responsibility becomes increasingly routinized in university development in terms of, for example, employment policy, campus construction, sustainability management and student life.

Finally, while universities have seen an associational and networking trend for some time now (Brankovic, 2018), more recent alliances often reflect universities’ new mandate as global governance actors banding together with other universities, IGOs and INGOs in SDG-targeted partnerships to create knowledge-practice synergies.

However, while a stronger premium on knowledge in globalized policymaking might have its benefits compared to traditional forms of decision-making (e.g. charismatic leadership), such science-based or ‘epistemic’ governance does not come without risks. When scientization of politics is reversed and science becomes

politicized, the strategic instrumentalization, manipulation and even oppression of knowledge by policymakers threatens scientific authority (Cozzens & Woodhouse, 1995; Normand, 2016). Recent examples of fake news, fake science and pseudoscience in the proximity of illiberal and populist politics reflect the vulnerability of scientific work.

Another risk emanates from the paradoxical situation in which, on the one hand, universities and their knowledge become increasingly globalized, while, on the other hand, policymakers proudly champion their universities as powerhouses of the national economy and figureheads of innovation and progress. This leads many countries to strategically invest in higher education and research to attract foreign investments and to export knowledge (Knight, 2018). With university knowledge becoming an important resource and asset in the global economy, the inter-university race for reputation, revenues, and researchers is oddly transposed to an unlevelled global geopolitical playing field (Moisio, 2018).

9.2 From Traditional Governance to Global Epistemic Governance

Global governance scholars have long neglected the knowledge dimension in the international sector. In the hard-boiled world of international relations scholarship where powerful nation-states compete (as in realist and classical Marxist perspectives) or negotiate rational solutions to reduce transaction costs and coordination problems (as in liberal perspectives), little attention was given to underlying epistemic mechanisms (see Zapp, 2017a, b for a review).

With the rise of a constructivist perspective in IR and a more integrated research agenda on globalization, particularly from the so-called world society scholarship, the focus shifted from 'hard', i.e. coercive or regulative, governance mechanisms to 'softer', i.e. normative, cognitive or epistemic governance mechanisms. In these accounts, the construction and power of ideas, knowledge, meanings, norms and cultural models take center stage (Barnett & Finnemore, 2004; Meyer et al., 1997; Parreira do Amaral, 2010; Wendt, 1999). Revising these traditional governance theories has also shifted the focus away from the traditional areas of security and economics now extending the analysis to an increasing number of globalized policy sectors, such as social policy, health, the environment as well as education and science.

The scholarly interest in knowledge construction as an analytical exercise and empirical task to understand globalization and global governance coincides with the diagnosis of global knowledge economy – one of the key narratives of the more recent period (Frank & Meyer, 2020). Although the precise causal links of such a knowledge economy are often awkwardly theorized by economists, a growing body of research documents the large-scale expansion of a highly educated labor force which transforms jobs, entire labor markets and many social and political domains

toward the ‘schooled society’, thus going far beyond the immediate economic gains (Baker, 2014).

It is beyond any doubt that policymakers seek to harness knowledge both as an economic resource (see below) but also to provide policymaking with the legitimacy and authority of science mainly derived from its universalism, independence, skepticism and disinterestedness – logics which are almost diametrically opposed to those reigning in politics (Merton, 1973 [1942]). Whether national policy-makers and educational administrators are *genuinely* interested in scientifically buttressing their decisions is difficult to ascertain, yet the notion of evidence-based policymaking has spread quickly across various policy areas (Drori et al., 2003; Normand, 2016; Zapp et al., 2018).

Driven by various stakeholders’ demands but also by their own ambitions, universities increasingly become active players in national and global policymaking. The following section identifies these stakeholders and identifies processes of such university actorhood.

9.3 The University as a Knowledge Actor in Global Governance

I argue that universities have begun to take on a new role in global governance by occupying a niche in extant structures by specializing in the provision of scientific, applicable and policy-relevant knowledge. This transformation is catalyzed by various driving forces both in the environment of universities but also within these themselves. I highlight government and funding agencies as well as ranking agencies as the main environmental actors involved before elaborating on university actorhood in more detail.

9.3.1 Governments and Funding Agencies

Although research evaluation systems or performance-based research funding systems (Hicks, 2012; Whitley & Gläser, 2007) are relatively recent developments, they are transforming research and scientific production around the world. These evaluation systems assess the merit of science according to national and international standards of excellence and, importantly, the societal impact of research (Watermeyer, 2019).

In his analysis of the oldest and most comprehensive research evaluation system, the British Research Excellence Framework (REF), Marques et al. (2017) finds that, over time, the notion of economic, cultural and social impact has increased. First discussed in 2009, it became the second most important score in REF 2014 and is considered to grow in importance for the upcoming REF 2021. Similar trends can

be found in many other European countries (Zapp et al., 2018). It seems that debates about the accountability, quality and relevance of the contemporary university find its confluence in the notion of impact and universities have begun to incorporate the new vocabulary in their organizational identity and incentive structures (Bornmann, 2012).

9.3.2 Ranking Agencies and Media

International ratings and rankings that emerged in the past two decades provide commensurable schemes for inter-organizational and individual comparison while creating new logics of quantification, distinction and stratification (Espeland & Sauder, 2007; Hazelkorn, 2015). As much as they fuel anxiety among some institutions, they catalyze competition and internal organizational change among others.

It has gone largely unnoticed in the literature that parallel to the shift in national funding priorities, the strong weight of research output in many rankings has recently been complemented by a new focus on wider university impact. Since 2019, one of the most prominent international rankings, the Times Higher Education (THE) World University Ranking, measures universities’ contributions to the achievement of the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). This novel ranking includes, among other areas, indicators of universities’ work towards gender equality, climate action and sustainable cities and communities. The most recent league tables are based on surveys of almost 800 universities from 85 countries around the world (THE, 2020). The THE methodology includes, for example, universities’ policies on academic freedom, their use of secure employment contracts and share of senior female academic staff. According to the THE editors, the new SDG-university ranking “is the world’s first global attempt to document evidence of higher education impact, offer a new way of defining excellence and recognize the fantastic work that universities do for the good of society to tackle some of our most pressing global issues” (O’Malley & Mitchell, 2019, no page).

9.3.3 University as ‘Actors’ and ‘Others’

While universities arose as transnational institutions, they came under the control of state authorities in the context of European nation-state building (Riddle, 1993; Rüegg, 2004). The subsequent institutionalization of the nation-state system worldwide further accelerated the “nationalization” of the university and the knowledge it produced (particularly in the social sciences and humanities) (Heilbron, 2014). However, during the twentieth century, especially its second half, the university became re-embedded in a more globalized social and political environment. The idea that society was exclusively national lost purchase, and a distinctly global social order emerged, to which the university was central (Meyer et al., 1997; Frank

& Meyer, 2007; Zapp & Lerch, 2020). Indeed, national policymakers' discourses have shifted from a focus on national development to one of global competitiveness including in the burgeoning private sector (Buckner & Zapp, 2020).

This recasting of society in global-individualist terms also redefined the role of the university in more globalized terms, including the objects of university knowledge. Testament to this shift, an analysis of over 700 UNESCO documents found that global discourses about universities shifted greatly between 1960 and 2010 (Buckner, 2017). In the decades following World War II, the emphasis was on "national development and universities were viewed as serving their local communities and regions," (Buckner, 2017, p. 484) but by the 1990s and 2000s universities were seen as "contributing to human development worldwide" (Buckner, 2017, p. 487).

These changes in the wider environment pose new challenges but also offer new opportunities for universities. Higher education institutions are facing pressures to become more autonomous, accountable, excellent, relevant, and international (Zapp et al., 2018). Confronted with stagnating funding, they diversify their sources and strategically position themselves globally through inter-university networks and elaborate internationalization strategies in an attempt to reduce uncertainty in an increasingly globalized and stratified field of higher education.

Many critical contributions see in universities' reaction to these pressures a desperate move toward more entrepreneurialism and managerialism in times of neoliberal public downsizing (Clark, 1998; Deem, 2001; Olssen & Peters, 2005). While such structural reforms as privatization, industry linkages, international recruitment and part-time contracting indeed do seem to be born out of a neoliberal template, I agree with scholarship that identifies a more profound transformation at work. In this view, universities are being re-conceptualized from 'specific organizations' of public administration (Musselin, 2007) to 'normal', 'complete', and even 'empowered' organizations (Musselin, 2009; Ramirez, 2006).

In this line of research, organizational actorhood becomes the main theoretical tenet (Krücken & Meier, 2006). Actorhood, here, describes organizations' structural and behavioral expansion by including autonomy, goal-orientation, accountability and social embeddedness or citizenship as part of their core identity (Bromley & Meyer, 2015). Indeed, a growing empirical body gives testimony to cross-national trends that reflect these new organizational traits. In part, these studies are linked to the notions of impact and relevance touched on above. For example, analyses of mission and vision statements, branding and marketing as well as reforms of formal structure map an organizational form that is in desperate search for a distinctive identity while, in fact, it is converging in mission, substance and structure across the world (see Zapp et al., forthcoming for a review).

The transformation towards organizational actorhood is key in understanding universities' emerging role in global governance. Universities' 'citizenship', 'social embeddedness' or 'responsibility' – as a key component of actorhood – refers to universities' openness to a wide variety of stakeholders and social issues (Bromley & Meyer, 2015; Ramirez, 2006; Sørensen et al., 2019). The counter model – the socially-buffered model – is increasingly under pressure amidst (inter)national

discourses on societal impact, relevance and usefulness and from the market as a mechanism that puts individual student choice before the preferences (and privileges) of the academic “nobility”, for instance the professoriate (Lenhardt, 2002, p. 287). Under these new conditions, the university morphs into an organization that pays attention to employees’ rights, diversity, work-life balance, environmental policy, an increasing number of associations and identity groups as well as the community in its broadest sense. For example, in 2005, the influential Carnegie Foundation shook U.S. higher education leaders by introducing a new classification for those institutions that engage with the community. Such new classification is meant to fundamentally alter universities’ relationship with the wider community (Driscoll, 2009). In sum, university-society relationships become more permeable and ‘ivory beauty’ increasingly delegitimized.

Seen from a social and organizational theory perspective, the responsible university reflects a particular form of actorhood, usually referred to as *otherhood*. Otherhood, here, refers to the social process of enacting agency for other actors (e.g. nation-states), non-actor entities (e.g. the world’s children; endangered species) and principles (e.g. human rights) (Meyer & Jepperson, 2000; Meyer, 2019; Zapp, 2020a). Almost ideal-typically, universities represent all these forms of otherhood. Respectively, they advise (or train students in advising) other actors – namely, individuals, organizations and states – in reforming their lives, organizational structures and policies through therapy, consultancy and policy recommendations with the aim to be healthier, more efficient and more just.

Universities also act on behalf of non-actor entities. For example, research on the children, the unorganized poor, refugees and migrants, special needs groups – in short, social inequality as one of the foundational topics in the social sciences – but also ecological issues do not only constitute the backbone of many disciplines, they also give testimony to science as a tool of empowerment. Finally, science and particularly the social sciences, while trying to be methodologically objective, inevitably show built-in normative principles that advocate human rights, democracy and justice, that is, the core of the liberal society (Suárez & Bromley, 2012).

It is important to note that the role of universities as *others* in global governance is facilitated by the particularity of world society. Lacking traditional mechanisms of control and authority, world society is essentially constructed through such ‘otherhood’, that is, through the diffusion and mimesis of cultural models, usually revolving around broad goals of progress and justice often provided in a rationalized form by (social) scientists (Meyer et al., 1997). Further, lacking a clear and designated center of power, conventional governance actors (nation-states) share such otherhood with non-state actors, often conceived of as a multi-actor and multi-level global governance architecture in international relations (Barnett & Finnemore, 2004). In such a decentralized and amorphous configuration, universities and science, very similar to international organizations (IOs), have found a particular niche as they are equipped with and provide for the legitimacy and authority of objective knowledge and the cultural models they fill (Zapp, 2020b).

The following section presents mechanisms that illustrate how universities’ otherhood activities help rethink the traditional imagery of global governance.

9.4 Mechanisms of University-Based Global Epistemic Governance – The Case of the United National Sustainable Development Goals

The following section presents four mechanisms of university commitment to global governance, namely the UN Sustainable Development Agenda as it marks a qualitative shift in university involvement. Sustainable development (SD) has become the overriding global agenda since 2015 when the 17 SD Goals were agreed upon by all 193 UN member states. Since then, important SD stakeholders have begun to see universities as key contributors in successfully implementing and monitoring the SD agenda and some see sustainability as the single most important ‘grand challenge’ and even a new kind of third mission of universities (Grau et al., 2017; Kaldeway, 2018; Trencher et al., 2013). Universities worldwide have started to discover their new role and have initiated profound internal changes. These include the alignment of research foci that reflect priorities high on the global governance agenda and a broadened teaching portfolio that meets the demand of professionalizing global governance experts. They also turn toward corporate/university social responsibility activities and, last, engage in networking activities to jointly act as agents of governance goals together with other universities and research institutes but also IGOs and INGOs. I will briefly review these trends.

9.4.1 *Aligning Research: Toward World Societal Impact*

As touched upon above, research is increasingly required to be of societal impact. With universities’ entering global governance settings and with the SDGs becoming a ubiquitous priority, such impact is now being rescaled to the world societal level and research activity is geared toward these global goals. Some examples are helpful in understanding the kind of research that is now being promoted.

For instance, the University of Manchester is developing a carbon footprint tool in order to identify and manage ‘carbon hot spots’ worldwide,¹ while the University of British Columbia is working on sensors and software to preserve biodiversity.² Similarly, researchers from the University of Auckland collaborate with the shipping industry to trace whales’ migration routes aiming at preventing fatal collisions.³ The KTH Royal Institute of Technology is creating a web-based platform

¹ <https://www.manchester.ac.uk/collaborate/business-engagement/knowledge-exchange/case-studies/carbon-calculator/>

² <https://sustain.ubc.ca/about/plans-policies-and-reports/2018-19-annual-sustainability-report/teaching-learning-research-0>

³ <https://researchspace.auckland.ac.nz/handle/2292/34693>

for teachers to introduce sustainable development in their courses.⁴ Importantly, the reorientation of research is happening across tiers and types of institutions including both the prestigious ETH Zurich and its energy-efficiency ‘2000 Watt Society Project’⁵ as well as small, liberal arts Oberlin College’s ‘Oberlin Project’ aiming at creating ‘one of the first climate positive cities in America’.⁶

The turn toward SDGs bring universities closer to traditional governance actors including in research. Analyzing the scientific output of more than 1325 international governmental and non-governmental organizations in the period 1970–2017, Zapp (2017b) identifies strong collaboration patterns between IOs and universities. Public universities are the most frequent collaborator for all IOs. On average, 40,000 publications have been co-authored with researchers from public postsecondary institutions.

It seems university academics have become regular partners of IO research and their relationship is recursive. IOs sometimes influence academic research as the case of the OECD and educational research in many European countries has shown (Zapp & Powell, 2016). However, more often, university knowledge makes its way into IO operations. With IOs discovering the power of evidence in thorny political discourses, they turn to universities to support their claims. Analyzing over N = 100 global reports published by IOs in the period 1947–2019, Zapp (2020a) finds that all reports now include references to scientific resources starting in the late 1980s. Some of these reports now resemble genuine large-scale literature reviews with thousands of academic references.

9.4.2 *Aligning Teaching: Training for Global Governance*

University knowledge immerses students and faculty into a universal collective reality, and legitimizes specialized personnel and indeed entire social sectors within a rationalized cosmological frame (Meyer et al., 2006; Baker, 2014). Importantly, universities train a growing number of global professions which can enter increasingly globalized labor markets.

Many new curricular inventions embrace a world model, as is common in proliferating environmental studies (Frank et al., 2011), global studies, and human rights programs (Suárez & Bromley, 2012) that contrast with the older academic portfolio made up mainly of the humanities and science (Frank & Gabler, 2006; see Zapp & Lerch, 2020 for a review). For example, Oxford University now offers a MSc in Global Governance and Diplomacy, and Copenhagen University has recently started

⁴https://www.kth.se/polopoly_fs/1.828499.1550157688!/Report%20KTHs%20overall%20environmental%20objectives%202017.pdf

⁵https://ethz.ch/content/dam/ethz/special-interest/mtec/cepe/cepe-dam/documents/research/projects/project_7742.pdf

⁶<http://www.oberlinproject.org>

its MSc in Climate Change.⁷ In 2019, KTH Royal Institute of Technology has just launched a new MA program in Sustainable Technology⁸ and the University of Manchester offers MOOCs on Water Supply and Sanitation Policy in Developing Countries as well as Global Health and Humanitarianism.⁹

In their sustainability report, the University of Bologna¹⁰ presents 1174 course units related to the SDGs. Some universities also offer Ph.D. programs on sustainability such as the University of McMaster's program in Global Health¹¹ or Gothenburg's interdisciplinary Ph.D. program From Research to Policy for Sustainable Development.¹² Add to this summer schools, internships, hackathons, awards and prizes, student associations, staff capacity building and other formats that emerge as part of universities' SD agenda.

In a larger context, analyzing $N = 465,000$ study programs worldwide, representing almost the entirety of the global higher education offer, Zapp and Lerch (2020) identify more than $N = 22,451$ study programs that explicitly offer degrees with some form of international orientation (e.g. international business, comparative law, global development, intercultural education).

Universities and university-trained global experts produce authoritative evidence and increasingly advance opinions in global debates but they also apply it back to their universities and campuses to which I now turn.

9.4.3 *Aligning Internal Policies: The Responsible and Sustainable Workplace*

Next to teaching and research, analyses of universities' additional missions have long unduly been confined to industry links. Universities' social responsibility has become a strong feature in the past two decades. As introduced above, an organization's social embeddedness (Ramirez 2006), citizenship (Bromley & Meyer, 2015) or responsibility (Sørensen et al., 2019) refers to its openness to a wide variety of stakeholders and social issues. Corporate social responsibility (CSR), long only discussed in the context of corporations, is slowly being used as a concept to interpret universities' internal changes (Larrán & Andrades Peña, 2017; Wigmore-Álvarez & Ruiz-Lozano, 2012). In recent years, CSR policies have emerged at universities

⁷ <https://www.ox.ac.uk/admissions/graduate/courses/msc-global-governance-and-diplomacy?wssl=1>, <https://www.hnee.de/en/Programmes/Master-degree/Global-Change-Management/Global-Change-Management-M.Sc.-GCM-E1841.htm>, <https://studies.ku.dk/masters/climate-change/>

⁸ <https://www.kth.se/en/studies/master/sustainable-technology/description-1.8721>

⁹ <https://www.manchester.ac.uk/study/online-blended-learning/what-you-can-study/moocs/>

¹⁰ <https://www.unibo.it/en/university/who-we-are/report-on-un-sdg>

¹¹ <https://globalhealth.mcmaster.ca/phd-global-health>

¹² https://www.gmv.gu.se/digitalAssets/1460/1460619_from-research-to-policy-for-sustainable-development%2D%2D-phd-course-spring-2014.pdf

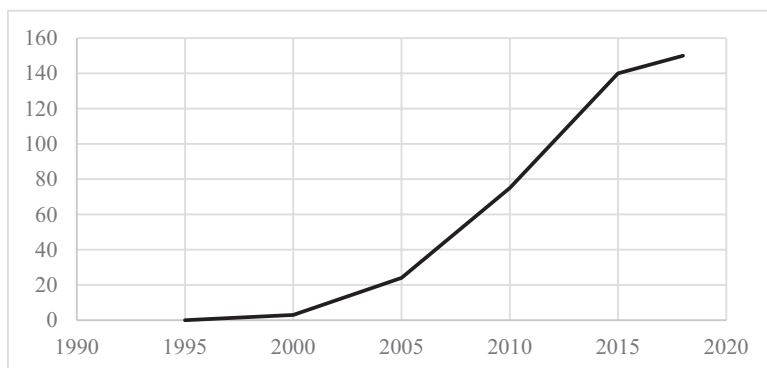


Fig. 9.1 Number of universities with corporate social responsibility charters. (Corporate Register, 2019)

around the world. The Corporate Register (2019), the world's largest CSR report directory, and the Global Reporting Initiative's Sustainability Disclosure Database (2019) together list more than 200 universities from around the world. Most of them reported their CSR activities for the first time in the last 5 years (Fig. 9.1).

These universities come from around the world and include public as well as private, highly prestigious and less well-known universities. Many of these CSR activities concern not only the internal organizational structure but aim at activities like promotion of global awareness, global student engagement and staff capacity building as well as research on global issues and projects focused on the campus-wide use of energy, water, transportation, waste, and food. These initiatives aim at transforming campuses into 'living laboratories' and 'testbeds for sustainability' and are often 'managerialized' and formalized through designated offices and organizational units – a strong indicator of lasting institutionalization (e.g. USRN, 2019).

9.4.4 Aligning Networks: Banding Together to Battle Global Problems

Universities now operate in nested organizational fields where local, national, regional and global levels interlock (Hüther & Krücken, 2016). In this nested field structure, universities increasingly band together in various forms of meta-organizations (e.g. alliances or associations), that is, organizations with other organizations as members. Brankovic (2018), tracing the emergence of university meta-organizations over time, finds 185 such associations, with most of them burgeoning in the past two decades. Some of these are small and exclusive (e.g. Universitas21 or League of European Research Universities), others are larger and span entire continents. (e.g. Network of Universities from the Capitals of Europe or the Association of African Universities) or even have a global scope (e.g. International Association of Universities) (Gunn & Mintrom, 2013; Jungblut et al., forthcoming).

Many of these associations not only come with benefits for their members but also involve costs and commitment stressing universities' genuine interest in promoting the cause of sustainability. Universities' now routinely engage with governments, international organizations, civil society, industry and, obviously, other universities. A growing number of universities join the UN Sustainable Development Solution Network (UN SDSN) which brings together universities, governmental agencies, research institutes and I(N)GOs to develop but also to promote policies and solutions for SD.¹³ In addition, the International Association of Universities (IAU) hosts the Higher Education and Research for Sustainable Development Initiative, which lists hundreds of universities that already act in these matters. It also serves as a platform and hub for myriad higher education coalitions committed to sustainability and its Iquitos Statement details how universities can contribute to the broader UN missions.

The role as world society others is clear in many ad-hoc coalitions. For example, the first World University Congress brought together 250 universities from 50 countries to discuss the responsibilities and duties of universities in the face of global problems including global warming, terrorism, poverty, migration and health (COMU, 2019). Another example is the case of UC3, a network of leading North-American universities recently established to tackle climate change problems.¹⁴ Universities for Poverty Alleviation also brings together academia, NGOs and companies to serve the local and international community (UPA, 2019).

In general, such new associational trends underline the novel role of universities as globally active and interconnected nodes where public, private, governmental and non-governmental, local, national and regional overlap. Interestingly, while THE World University Impact Ranking 2019 (based on 11 SDGs) allows universities to self-select 10 SDGs, one indicator – SDG 17: partnerships for goals – is compulsory to report on. It seems that universities, while driven by competition to band together in exclusive circles, also start to team up for the public good of global progress.

9.5 Discussion: On the Consequences and Risks of Global Epistemic Governance

The major shifts toward a stronger role of universities in global governance described in this article may offer the historical opportunity to replace traditional power-based and charismatic forms of authority and decision-making with rational knowledge. Yet, the impartiality and universality of science, not least its epistemological core, are challenged by strategies to instrumentalize and undermine science for political purposes and by nation-states' attempt to (re)gain the university as a symbol of national grandeur and geopolitical positioning. I will elaborate on these perils.

¹³ <https://www.unsdsn.org/networks-overview>

¹⁴ <https://secondnature.org/initiative/uc3-coalition/>

The increase in importance of academic knowledge for policy-making, often referred to as evidence-based policymaking, has been described as the scientization of politics (e.g. Normand, 2016). At the same time, such scientization also harbors the risk of the politicization of science (Klees & Edwards, 2014; Cozzens & Woodhouse, 1995). Policymakers borrow the authority of scientific research to bolster political action and, conversely, scientists find in such political interest opportunities to refill drained funding lines, to win internal funding battles and to increase their own legitimacy and leverage in global governance. Thus, stressing the role of research in global governance does not imply that these discourses have become depoliticized spaces.

Evidence is often complex, ambiguous, fragmented and context-dependent, which makes science vulnerable to manipulation, contestation and even outright oppression. These three forms of the science-politics nexus are increasingly supported by empirical data. First, in what has been called epistemic drift (Elzinga, 1997) researchers seem to align their interests to external demands often sacrificing their own internal agenda. Conversely, policymakers may draw only very selectively on scientific evidence in order to support their own agenda (Steiner-Khamisi et al. 2020). Second, evidence might be fabricated or at least produced with very specific anticipations in mind. For example, research on the impact of school privatization at the IO-level may, in some instances, produce highly predictable evidence in accordance with the authors' political leanings (Zapp, 2020a). Similarly, it has become a popular populist knee-jerk reaction to reject facts while providing 'counter-evidence'. Presidents Trumps and Bolsonaro's repeated refusal to accept climate change as a scientific consensus or to listen to public health expertise in the current COVID-19 pandemic while pointing to alternative facts and findings are particularly instructive examples (Barerra et al., 2020; Hopf et al., 2019). Finally, some authoritarian and illiberal regimes interpret universities as pursuing a political agenda and have begun to overtly oppress academic institutions. The recent banning of gender studies from university teaching, the hassling of the international Central European University as well as the tight government grip on the Academy of Science in Viktor Orban's Hungary might be one prescient and recent example (Scholars at Risk, 2019).

These variants of the science-politics nexus show that with university knowledge increasingly pervading modern societies and with universities taking a more active part in public debates, the relationship with their surrounding environment has grown thornier.

Turning to new geopolitical configurations in the global knowledge economy, paradoxically, with the growing centrality of globalized university knowledge in modern societies grows the interest of national policymakers to harness its potential. Nobel prize winners are championed as a national pride (Baram-Tsabari & Segev, 2018; Nietzel, 2019), universities now replace military sites during presidential visits and honorary degrees are given as a diplomatic nicety (e.g. US UK Embassy, 2019). Countries launch "excellence initiatives" and other large-scale research funding programs to boost their science and innovation systems (Zapp et al., 2018; Ramirez et al., 2016), 'education hubs', 'knowledge villages', 'smart

cities' and 'technopoles' are built to attract foreign talent and capital (Knight, 2018; Moio, 2018), higher education becomes the most frequently included sector in the General Agreement in Trades and Services (WTO, 2020) and the G20 group, representing the most important economies in the world, has recently begun to implement a research scorecard to assess the performance of national research systems (Web of Science Group 2019).

In stark contrast to its epistemological core and presumably in contrast to most scientists' attitudes, the university and higher education become (re)cast as a geopolitical and geo-economical object and commodity. Moio and Kangas (2016) and Moio (2018) note that the alleged internationality and globality of knowledge-related spaces and places (including the university) often obscure the territorial claims and market interests held by cities, regions, states and supranational entities. In this sense, actors involved in the knowledge economy – particularly the university – become (often unwillingly) a geopolitical unit of competition between territories of wealth, power and spatial territoriality (Moio, 2018).

Such reclaiming of the university in territorial categories often works through funding. It is not surprising that scientists – increasingly expected to win external funding – need to simultaneously prove how their research impacts on local, national, supranational and global communities. In some countries (notably the U.S.), such national bias in research has been found across disciplines and research fields and while the curriculum is slowly being internationalized the vast majority of university knowledge, particularly in the social sciences, is still anchored in national and statist frames (Zapp & Lerch, 2020).

Historically, with universities balancing political, religious, student, professorial and market demands, such a more critical view complicates the understanding of this peculiar organizational entity in the twenty-first century where those demands increasingly become pluriscalar. Ironically, while becoming more and more its own master, the university remains the servant of many (local and national, regional and global) patrons with often opposed expectations. It remains a crucial task of further empirical research to assess how the modern university can cope with these pressures while finding its new role as the voice of reason in global discourses.

9.6 Conclusion

In the more recent globalized period, the university has jolted into the global governance arena with sustainable development at its core as a source of evidence, experts, and good practices. At the same time, the more universities globalize themselves and seek proximity to global decision-making, the more national policymakers may try to rein them in, harvest their fruits, if not question the legitimacy of science altogether. If universities want to preserve their unique status as independent knowledge arbiters in global governance and even reshuffle power structures traditionally skewed towards politics and markets, they have to make sure to not only follow the global agenda but begin to actively shape it.

Future research may benefit from delving deeper into the increasingly active and activist role of universities vis-à-vis wider social and political issues. Interestingly, parallel to the populist backlash and growing commodification of higher education, students, academics and even university leaders have begun to take a strikingly overt role in recent public controversies around the world including 'Rhodes Must Fall', 'Black Lives Matter', '#MeeToo', 'Scientists for Future', and Covid-19. Whether such new activism is a response to the new political climate or even at the root of the anti-scientific tilt among particular political leaders would be an important task for further research interested in the future role and significance of universities in modern societies.

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